

Project Communication Management

SECTION: Why It Matters

Studies consistently show project managers spend roughly 75–90% of their time communicating — in meetings, emails, reports, and informal conversations. Poor communication is one of the most cited causes of project failure.

SECTION: The Communication Model

A message passes through: **Sender** → **Encode** → **Message (+ Medium)** → **Noise** → **Decode** → **Receiver** → **Feedback**.

"Noise" refers to anything that distorts the message (technical jargon, language barriers, distractions, cultural differences). Effective communication planning tries to minimize noise and confirm understanding via feedback loops.

SECTION: Communication Channels Formula

The number of potential communication channels in a team grows quickly with team size:

Channels = $n(n - 1) / 2$, where n = number of people.

Example: a team of 6 people has $6 \times 5 / 2 = 15$ channels. This is why large teams need more formal communication structures (status reports, defined meeting cadences) rather than relying on ad-hoc conversation.

SECTION: Communications Management Plan

Typically documents, for each stakeholder or stakeholder group:

- What information they need
- Format (report, dashboard, email, meeting)
- Frequency (daily standup, weekly status report, monthly steering committee)
- Method/medium (in-person, video call, written document)
- Who is responsible for sending it
- Escalation path for issues

SECTION: Types of Communication

- **Formal vs Informal**: formal (status reports, contracts) vs informal (hallway conversations, chats).
- **Written vs Verbal**: written creates a record and is better for complex/technical information; verbal is faster and better for building relationships or resolving ambiguity quickly.
- **Push vs Pull vs Interactive**:
 - ***Push***: sent to specific recipients who need it (emails, memos) — no guarantee it was received/understood.

- ***Pull***: recipients access information themselves (intranet, shared repositories, dashboards) — used for large audiences or reference material.
- ***Interactive***: multidirectional exchange (meetings, calls) — most effective for ensuring common understanding but most time-consuming.

SECTION: Status Reports and Meetings

- **Status report**: describes where the project currently stands relative to the schedule and budget baseline.
- **Progress report**: describes what has been accomplished during a specific period.
- **Forecast report**: predicts future project status and progress.
- **Kick-off meeting**: held at project start to align stakeholders on goals, scope, and roles.
- **Stand-up/daily scrum** (Agile context): short daily sync — what was done, what's next, blockers.

SECTION: Barriers to Effective Communication

- Cultural and language differences in distributed/global teams
- Ambiguous or overly technical language
- Information overload
- Lack of feedback loops to confirm understanding
- Virtual team challenges (time zones, lack of non-verbal cues)

SECTION: Common Exam Angles

- Calculate the number of communication channels given team size (and how it changes when members are added/removed).
- Distinguish push, pull, and interactive communication with examples.
- Identify the right report type (status/progress/forecast) for a scenario.
- Explain why communication planning matters more as team size or geographic distribution increases.